

CHANGE OF GUARD
New CM D.K. Shivakumar with Siddaramaiah after the latter stepped down, Bengaluru, May 28

IANS

never acknowledged it. As the months wore on, it became the single biggest distraction for a government that had come to power on the back of its strongest mandate since 1989.

The high command had intervened before, most recently last December, nudging the two men to meet informally and keep a lid on things. That, in hindsight, was the leadership buying time. The opening came in early May, with the conclusion of a high-stakes round of state elections in which the Congress won Kerala and emerged as a partner in the Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) coalition in Tamil Nadu.

Its position now more secure in the South, the party decided to make a firm move in Karnataka. On May 26, Siddaramaiah was summoned to Delhi for a long day of meetings, including a tête-à-tête with Rahul Gandhi. The ostensible reason was a discussion on possible Rajya Sabha and legislative council nominees for the elections due in June, but the real purpose was the shake-up at the top.

Siddaramaiah went gracefully. "I had always maintained that I will resign when the high command asks me to. Accordingly, I did so," he said at a press conference on May 28, flanked by DKS and other ministers. He revealed he had been offered a Rajya Sabha berth "but I humbly declined...I have no interest". Sidda said he would remain a legislator for the two years left of his term. "I will continue in active politics in the state and fight the communal forces."

The exiting chief minister's insistence on remaining active in state politics could become a headache for the man who has replaced him. "Siddaramaiah is a mass leader. If he stays engaged, he will either take on the role of a watchdog or a disruptor within the system. The decision to accept the caste survey results on the eve of his departure suggests the second role is more likely," says a Congress general secretary.

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TRUSTED TROUBLESHOOTER

But DKS is no pushover either. The Congress's "troubleshooter" tag is not mere party folklore, but a job description earned over a quarter of a century. From 2002, when he spirited away some 40 Congress legislators to a Bengaluru resort to help Vilasrao Deshmukh survive a no-confidence vote in Maharashtra, to 2017, when he engineered the late Ahmed Patel's improbable Rajya Sabha victory from Gujarat, and then the 2018 Karnataka hung verdict, when DKS kept the flock together, denying B.S. Yediyurappa and the BJP a majority and paving the way for the Congress-JD(S) coalition, Shivakumar has repeatedly proved his worth as the party's crisis manager. As late as in February 2024, the party had rushed him to Himachal Pradesh, where cross-voting had imperilled the Sukhvinder Sukhu government. He emerged to declare it safe. The resorts, the negotiations, the late-night vigils, this is the terrain where Shivakumar's politics thrives.

That utility has bought him unusual standing with the Gandhis. They have repaid the trust in kind: Sonia Gandhi visited him in Tihar Jail in October 2019, during the weeks he spent in custody in an alleged money laundering case. Months later, even with that case live,